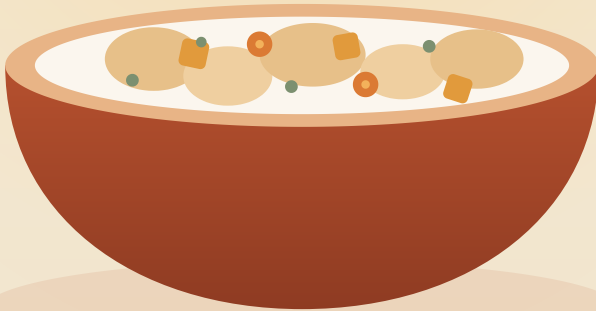
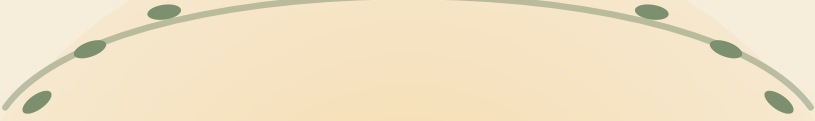




THE COMPLETE GUIDE FOR OWNERS

Natural Feeding for Dogs

From a safe transition to the everyday bowl





"Feeding your dog well doesn't have to be complicated — it just has to be done with the right information, at the right pace."



This guide was created for first-time owners who want to move their dogs onto a natural diet safely, gradually, and with real nutritional grounding — no fads, no miracle promises.

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 IMPORTANT NOTICE

This material is educational and does not replace an individual assessment by a licensed veterinarian. Always validate your dog's diet with a professional before starting the transition.

Why this book exists

If you picked up this guide, chances are one question has been on your mind for a while: *"should I be feeding my dog differently?"*

Maybe you saw a video, read a post, or heard a friend talk about natural feeding. Maybe your dog has allergies, sensitive digestion, or just seems a little "off" — and you feel their food could be better. Whatever brought you here, I want to be upfront about one thing:

A COMMITMENT TO YOU

Natural feeding isn't a trend, but it isn't magic either. Done well, it can transform your dog's health and energy. Done without guidance, it can create silent deficiencies. This guide exists to give you the safe path between those two extremes.

My goal here isn't to sell you a trendy diet, or to convince you that kibble is "poison." It's to give you clear, safe, applicable information — so you, a first-time owner, can make this transition with confidence, at your own pace.

Over the next five chapters, we'll walk through a structured journey together:

- ✓ You'll understand **what natural feeding actually is** and clear up the most common myths.
- ✓ You'll learn the **nutritional fundamentals** every dog needs, without relying on guesswork.
- ✓ You'll get a **proven, gradual transition plan** you can follow step by step.
- ✓ You'll discover how to **build balanced meals** in practice, with real recipes.
- ✓ You'll learn to **sustain the routine** long-term, with confidence and independence.



This isn't a book to read once and shelve. It's a reference guide — come back to it whenever you have questions or need to make an adjustment.

Natural feeding, done properly, takes commitment, but it doesn't have to be complicated or intimidating. Thousands of owners, with the same uncertainty you might be feeling right now, have made this transition successfully. With the right information and a little patience, you will too.

LET'S GET STARTED

Turn the page and start with Chapter 1 — the conceptual foundation that will give you confidence for everything that follows.



CHAPTER ONE

Understanding Natural Feeding

Myths, truths, and the first steps to deciding whether this journey is right for you and your dog.

- What natural feeding actually is
- Kibble vs. natural food, without demonizing either
- The most common myths among beginners
- Signs your dog could benefit

CHAPTER 01

1.1 What natural feeding actually is

Natural feeding is a canine nutrition method based on **whole, unprocessed foods** — meat, organs, eggs, vegetables and, in some protocols, fruit and grains — prepared and balanced specifically to meet a dog's nutritional needs.

It's worth underlining the word **balanced**. This isn't about feeding your dog leftovers from your own plate, or improvising with whatever's in the fridge. There's real science behind it — ratios of protein, fat, calcium, phosphorus, fibre, and micronutrients that need to be respected.

COOKED (HOME-COOKED)

Ingredients are cooked before serving. Easier to digest and lower contamination risk.

Recommended for beginners — the focus of this guide.

RAW (BARF-STYLE)

Ingredients are served raw. Requires extra hygiene, handling care, and more experience from the owner.

1.2 Kibble vs. Natural Food

A common mistake is treating this as a battle between "villain" and "hero." That's not how it works. Good-quality kibble is formulated to be nutritionally complete, with tightly controlled nutrient levels — it exists for good reason: convenience and guaranteed nutritional consistency.

Natural feeding, on the other hand, offers higher palatability, fresh ingredients, and the ability to tailor the diet to specific needs. The real difference isn't "which is better," but **which demands more attention and knowledge from the owner** — and that knowledge is exactly what this guide will give you.

1.3 Myths that scare beginners

Before moving on, let's clear up a few beliefs that tend to cause fear or rushed decisions.

MYTH

"Natural feeding is always cheaper than kibble."

REALITY

Not always. The real payoff isn't in your wallet — it's in nutritional quality and how your dog's body responds.

MYTH

"Dogs are basically wolves, so they can eat anything raw and unprepared."

REALITY

Domestic dogs developed different digestive adaptations from their wild ancestors over thousands of years.

MYTH

"If it's natural, you can't get it wrong."

REALITY

Poorly balanced natural food can cause serious calcium and phosphorus deficiencies — silent for months.

MYTH

"The switch can happen overnight."

REALITY

Abrupt switches cause diarrhea and food refusal. The correct schedule is in Chapter 3.

With these myths out of the way, you're better prepared to make this decision with clarity — not fear or excitement.

1.4

Real benefits and the risks of getting it wrong

Done well, natural feeding brings visible benefits: shinier coat and healthier skin, firmer stools with less odour, more energy, and better outcomes for dogs with food allergies.

⚠️ RISKS OF A POORLY DONE TRANSITION

Calcium and phosphorus deficiency — compromises bones and joints, especially in puppies.

Nutrient excess without the cofactors needed for proper absorption.

Silent imbalances that build up over time with no immediate symptoms.

Food contamination, when preparation doesn't follow proper hygiene practices.

None of these risks should scare you off — they exist precisely to explain why this guide follows such a careful structure. Each chapter removes one of these risks, one step at a time.

1.5

Signs the switch could help

- ✓ Recurring food allergies or sensitivities
- ✓ Frequent digestive issues with no clear cause
- ✓ Dull coat or persistent itching
- ✓ Low acceptance of current kibble
- ✓ Obesity or trouble maintaining a healthy weight
- ✓ Senior dogs who need more digestible diets

1.6 Quick self-check

Before we move on to nutritional fundamentals, take this quick self-check. There's no "right" answer — it's just here to help you place yourself on the journey.

- ✓ Do I have the time to prepare meals regularly?
- ✓ Am I willing to be patient through the process, without expecting instant results?
- ✓ Do I have — or am I willing to get — veterinary guidance to validate the diet?
- ✓ Do I understand that this change is gradual, not instant?

If you answered "yes" — or even "not yet, but I want to learn" — to these questions, you're already on the right track.



Up next: the nutritional fundamentals behind every well-built natural diet.



CHAPTER TWO

Nutritional Fundamentals

What every owner needs to know before building the first bowl — no jargon, no complexity.

- Protein, fat, carbs, and fibre
- Calcium, phosphorus, and the minerals that matter most
- The forbidden foods list
- How to calculate the right portion

CHAPTER 02

2.1 The four building blocks of a canine diet

Every dog, regardless of size, needs a balance across four major macronutrient groups.

PROTEIN

The central pillar of the diet. Supplies amino acids for muscle maintenance, enzymes, hormones, and skin and coat renewal. Meat, eggs, and organs are the most bioavailable sources.

FAT

The main source of concentrated energy, essential for absorbing vitamins A, D, E and K. Watch the amount — excess fat is one of the most common causes of pancreatitis in dogs.

CARBOHYDRATES

Not the villain they're made out to be — well-chosen sources (rice, sweet potato, oats) provide slow-release energy.

FIBRE

Found in vegetables and greens. Key for gut health and blood sugar regulation.

2.2 Essential vitamins and minerals

This is where most poorly done transitions cause harm — pay extra attention here.

⚠️ **CALCIUM AND PHOSPHORUS: THE MOST CRITICAL PAIR**

These need to stay in a balanced ratio (roughly **1.2 to 2 parts calcium for every 1 part phosphorus**). Meat alone is rich in phosphorus but low in calcium — without an adequate source (finely ground eggshell, bone meal, or a specific supplement), deficiency builds progressively, even if the dog looks healthy.

B-COMPLEX, E AND ZINC

Important for skin, the nervous system, and metabolism. Liver and other organs are excellent sources.

OMEGA-3

Found in sardines and fish oil. Anti-inflammatory action, plus cardiovascular, joint, and cognitive support.

No first-time owner should try to "guess" these micronutrient amounts. That's why we'll cover supplementation in Chapter 4 and veterinary follow-up in Chapter 5.

2.3 Water, digestion, and the gut

Water tends to be the most overlooked nutrient — and one of the most important. It's involved in nearly every metabolic process. Dogs on a natural diet visibly drink less water (thanks to the moisture in their food), but fresh water should always be available.

The gut is one of the most sensitive organs during any dietary change. It's home to the **gut microbiota** — beneficial bacteria that support digestion and strengthen immunity. Abrupt diet changes disrupt this microbiota, causing the digestive symptoms we'll learn to avoid in Chapter 3.

2.4 Forbidden foods

The most important section in this chapter for immediate safety. Memorize this list.

STRICTLY FORBIDDEN

Chocolate · Onion, garlic and chives · Grapes and raisins · Avocado
· Macadamia nuts · Xylitol (sweetener) · Raw bread dough ·
Cooked bones · Excess salt, sugar, or processed seasoning

Take a photo of this list and stick it on the fridge. Many emergency vet visits happen from well-meaning slip-ups, without knowing the real risk involved.

2.5 How much to feed: calculating by weight

Unlike kibble, which comes with a ready-made feeding chart, natural feeding requires you to calculate the right portion. There's a widely used baseline formula to start from:

1.5–2%

of body weight
Sedentary / senior /
overweight

2–3%

of body weight
Adults, normal
activity

4–5%

of body weight
Puppies / pregnant /
very active

This calculation is **a starting point, not a fixed rule**. Fine-tuning happens by watching your dog's body over the following weeks — if they're gaining more weight than expected, reduce the portion; if they're losing weight, increase it.

PRACTICAL TIP

Split the total daily amount into 2 to 3 meals throughout the day, and re-check your dog's weight every 2 weeks during the early stages.

2.6 Differences by life stage

Natural feeding isn't "one recipe for every dog." Needs change throughout a dog's life.

STAGE	KEY FOCUS
Puppies	Rapid bone growth — extra attention to the calcium/phosphorus ratio.
Adults	Stable needs, focused on weight maintenance and energy.
Seniors	Easily digestible protein, lower calorie density, joint support.
Special conditions	Individualized diets with a veterinary nutritionist's guidance.



With the nutritional fundamentals covered, you now understand the "what" and the "why." Next, we turn it into action.



CHAPTER THREE

Planning the Transition

A safe, day-by-day plan to make the switch without upset stomachs, food refusal, or digestive issues.

- A gradual 10-day schedule
- How to read your dog's reactions
- What to do if something goes off track
- A practical transition checklist

CHAPTER 03

3.1 Why it can't happen all at once

A dog's digestive system works in balance with whatever food it routinely receives. When you switch diets abruptly, that balance breaks all at once, and the most common result is diarrhea, vomiting, and refusal of the new food.

THE #1 CAUSE OF A FAILED TRANSITION

It's not the diet itself — it's **rushing**. A well-done transition respects the body's timeline, spread over 7 to 10 days for healthy dogs.

3.2 The day-by-day schedule

Baseline schedule for healthy adult dogs with no known digestive sensitivity. If your dog has a pre-existing condition, check with a vet before starting.

1-2
DAYS

25% natural · 75% kibble

Adjustment phase: introduce the new smell, taste, and texture, and watch for initial acceptance.

3-4
DAYS

50% natural · 50% kibble

Stools may change consistency slightly — expected, as long as there's no watery diarrhea.

5-6
DAYS

75% natural · 25% kibble

Extra attention to appetite, energy, and stool consistency — the body is nearly adjusted.

7-10
DAYS

100% natural feeding

Follow the ratios and portions from Chapter 2. The focus now is fine-tuning, not transitioning.

This schedule is a safe reference, not a rigid formula — the next section teaches you to "listen" to your dog and adjust the pace as needed.

3.3 Watching your dog's reactions

Throughout the transition, three signs deserve daily attention:

APPETITE

Should stay steady or improve. Persistent refusal signals too fast a pace.

ENERGY

Should stay normal. Prolonged lethargy needs a closer look.

STOOLS

Slightly softer early on is expected. Blood or mucus needs attention.

PRACTICAL TIP

Keep a simple daily log (even in your phone's notes app) tracking appetite, energy, and stools during the 10 days. It makes it much easier to spot patterns and act quickly if something's off.

3.4 Diarrhea, upset stomach, or refusal: what to do

For **soft stools**, step back one stage in the schedule for 2–3 days, then resume more slowly. For **isolated vomiting**, check if it's linked to a recently introduced ingredient. For **food refusal**, leave the bowl out for 15–20 minutes and remove it without forcing the issue.

⊕ **CALL THE VET RIGHT AWAY IF**

Bloody or very watery diarrhea lasting more than a day · Repeated vomiting · Intense lethargy · Food refusal for more than 24 hours · Any sign of rapid decline.

3.5 **Common beginner mistakes**

- ⚠ **Rushing the schedule out of anxiety** , skipping stages.
- ⚠ **Introducing too many new ingredients** at once.
- ⚠ **Giving up at the first sign** of soft stools, without telling normal adjustment apart from a real issue.
- ⚠ **Neglecting calcium** as early as the first days with a high proportion of natural food.

3.6 Practical transition checklist

BEFORE YOU START

- ✓ Talk to your vet about the transition
- ✓ Calculate the daily portion based on weight (Ch. 2)
- ✓ Organize ingredients and calcium sources ahead of time

DURING THE TRANSITION

- ✓ Follow the gradual ratio schedule
- ✓ Watch appetite, energy, and stools daily
- ✓ Avoid introducing too many new ingredients at once



Up next: the fun part – building your dog's bowl in practice, with real recipes.



CHAPTER FOUR

Building the Bowl

Recipes, a weekly menu, and a shopping list — the hands-on (and most fun) part of this guide.

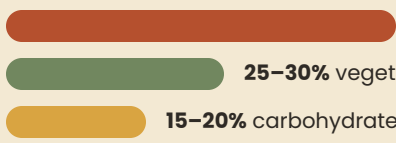
- The structure of a balanced bowl
- 3 complete, step-by-step recipes
- A ready-to-use weekly menu
- A weekly shopping list

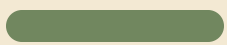
CHAPTER 04

4.1 The structure of a balanced bowl

The recipes and menus in this chapter are safe starting points for **healthy adult dogs**. They don't replace an individual assessment — but they're a solid, reliable base to start using right away.

BASELINE BOWL RATIO

 **50%** animal protein

 **25–30%** vegetables

 **15–20%** carbohydrate

+ a source of calcium and healthy fat, added in a small amount.

This ratio isn't a fixed rule — it varies with age, activity level, and health (Chapter 2) — but it works very well as an everyday reference.

4.2 Protein sources and how to rotate them

Rotate between **2 to 3 protein sources** throughout the week to lower the risk of sensitivities that can develop from repeated exposure to a single ingredient.

MAIN MEATS

Chicken, lean beef, cold-water fish (sardines), and occasionally lean pork.

ORGANS AND EGG

Liver and heart (5–10% of total protein) and cooked egg, a few times a week.

4.3 Safe vegetables and fruit

Always served **cooked and mashed** — dogs don't digest raw, whole fibre well.

Vegetables: pumpkin or squash, carrot, zucchini, green beans, broccoli, and kale (in moderation).

Fruit (occasional treat): apple without seeds, papaya, watermelon, and banana (in moderation).

Always check the forbidden foods list in Chapter 2 before introducing anything new.

4.4 Supplementation: when it's necessary

Calcium supplementation is **not optional** on a home-cooked natural diet — the natural calcium-to-phosphorus ratio in common foods doesn't meet a dog's needs on its own.

⚠ MOST COMMON CALCIUM SOURCES

Finely ground, crushed eggshell · Bone meal (from specialty stores) · Calcium supplements made for dogs, already balanced with phosphorus.

The exact amount should be calculated based on your dog's weight and the full composition of the bowl — it's best to have a veterinarian validate this dosage the first time you build the menu.

COMPLEMENTARY SUPPLEMENTS (NOT MANDATORY)

Fish oil (omega-3) and, in some cases, specific vitamin blends — based on each dog's individual needs.

4.5 Sample weekly menu

For a healthy adult dog with no restrictions. Adjust portions using the Chapter 2 calculation, and always include the calcium source.

DAY	PROTEIN	VEG + CARB
Monday	Cooked chicken	Pumpkin · Rice
Tuesday	Lean beef	Carrot · Sweet potato
Wednesday	Sardine (deboned)	Zucchini · Rice
Thursday	Cooked chicken	Broccoli · Sweet potato
Friday	Beef + liver	Green beans · Rice
Saturday	Cooked egg	Pumpkin · Sweet potato
Sunday	Cooked chicken	Carrot · Rice

+ ground eggshell added to every main meal.

This menu is a reference model — mix and match proteins and vegetables freely through the week, keeping the ratios from 4.1 and the calcium supplementation.

RECIPE 4.6 — MAIN MEAL

MAIN MEAL

Chicken & Pumpkin Mash

Soft texture, great for everyday meals and for dogs starting the transition



PREP TIME
25 min



DIFFICULTY
Easy



BEST FOR
Transition

INGREDIENTS

- Cooked chicken breast
- Cooked pumpkin
- Ground eggshell
- Cooking water (if needed)

METHOD

- 1 Cook the chicken breast in water, with no seasoning, until fully cooked.
- 2 Cook the pumpkin separately until soft.
- 3 Shred the chicken and mash the pumpkin, mixing until you get a smooth blend.
- 4 Stir in the calculated calcium (ground eggshell) and mix well.
- 5 Serve warm — never hot — in the portion calculated for your dog's weight.

WHY THIS RECIPE • MAKES ~500G (1.1 LB)

The soft texture makes it easier to accept during the first days of transition (Ch. 3), and the chicken + pumpkin combo is easy on digestion. Adjust the ratio based on your dog's daily amount (Ch. 2).

RECIPE 4.6 — MAIN MEAL



Beef & Sweet Potato Meatballs

Great for portioning and freezing — convenience for the whole week



PREP TIME

35 min



DIFFICULTY

Medium



BEST FOR

Weekly routine

INGREDIENTS

- Ground beef, cooked
- A drizzle of fish oil
- Cooked sweet potato
- Ground eggshell

METHOD

- 1 Cook the sweet potato until soft and mash well while still warm.
- 2 Mix in the cooked ground beef.
- 3 Add a drizzle of fish oil and the ground eggshell, mixing thoroughly.
- 4 Shape into small meatballs, sized appropriately for your dog.
- 5 Serve at room temperature, or freeze in individual portions.



STORAGE • MAKES ~600G (8-10 PIECES)

Freeze in portions already calculated for one meal. Thaw in the fridge the night before — never at room temperature.

RECIPE 4.6 — TREAT



Dehydrated Liver Treats

Perfect for training and rewards — in moderation



PREP TIME

1h10



DIFFICULTY

Easy



BEST FOR

Training / rewards

INGREDIENTS

- Beef or chicken liver
- (No other ingredients needed)

- 1 Slice the liver into thin, even strips.
- 2 Bake at a low temperature (about 200°F / 100°C) for roughly 1 hour.
- 3 Flip halfway through, until dry and crisp.
- 4 Let cool completely and store in a sealed container.

Note: always offer in moderation — liver is concentrated in vitamin A.

Weekly Shopping List

Based on the weekly menu in 4.5, for a medium-sized dog (adjust quantities to your dog's weight).



PROTEIN

- ☐ Chicken breast
- ☐ Lean ground beef
- ☐ Fresh sardines
- ☐ Beef liver
- ☐ Eggs



VEGETABLES

- ☐ Pumpkin
- ☐ Carrot
- ☐ Zucchini
- ☐ Broccoli
- ☐ Green beans



CARBOHYDRATES

- ☐ White rice
- ☐ Sweet potato



SUPPLEMENTS

- ☐ Saved eggshells
- ☐ Fish oil

Batch-cook every 3–4 days and freeze individually labelled portions with the prep date — it saves time and cuts down on waste (more in Chapter 5).



CHAPTER FIVE

Sustaining the Routine

Health, follow-up, and longevity — turning all of this into a routine that lasts.

- Safe food storage
- Signs the diet is working
- Veterinary follow-up
- Adjustments through your dog's life

CHAPTER 05

5.1 Safe storage and prep

Unlike kibble, natural food needs careful storage. The most recommended approach is **batch cooking**: cook every 3–4 days, portion it out, and freeze anything you won't use within 48 hours.

BEST PRACTICES

Never re-freeze a thawed portion · Keep utensils and containers clean · Don't leave food out for more than 30–40 minutes at room temperature · Use labelled containers with the prep date.

5.2 Signs it's working

POSITIVE SIGNS

Shiny coat · Well-formed stools with less odour · Consistent energy · Healthy weight · Good acceptance of meals.

WARNING SIGNS

Progressive weight loss · Dull coat or excessive shedding · Chronically soft stools · Lethargy · Excessive thirst or urination.

5.3 Veterinary follow-up

⬆ THE SINGLE MOST IMPORTANT MESSAGE IN THIS GUIDE

A well-done natural diet **doesn't replace** veterinary follow-up — it **depends** on it.

After the first 2–3 months on a natural diet, get basic bloodwork done (calcium, phosphorus, kidney and liver function) to confirm the diet is actually meeting your dog's needs in practice — not just on paper. After that, checkups every 6 months to a year are enough.

If possible, find a veterinarian with experience in animal nutrition to review your menu — that professional can catch fine-tuning details that no educational material can replace.

5.4 Adjusting through your dog's life

The diet that works today won't necessarily be the right one a few years from now. Review it whenever there's a change in life stage, weight, activity, or a new health diagnosis.

5.5 Handling curveballs

SHORT TRIPS

Bring frozen portions in an insulated bag, or keep a good-quality kibble on hand as a temporary backup.

ILLNESS OR POST-SURGERY

Always follow your vet's specific guidance — they may recommend a temporary therapeutic diet.

ROUTINE CHANGES

A temporary drop in appetite is normal. If refusal lasts more than 24–48 hours, contact your vet.

One isolated hiccup doesn't undo months of well-managed natural feeding. Common-sense flexibility is part of a sustainable routine.

5.6 What's next

We've reached the end of this guide — but this isn't the end of your journey as an owner. It's just the beginning, now with a solid, safe foundation.

Keep watching, adjusting, and learning alongside your dog. Revisit the ratios as they move through life stages, keep veterinary follow-up on schedule, and don't hesitate to seek professional guidance whenever a specific question comes up.

If you've followed all five chapters closely, you're already well ahead of most owners who try this switch alone, without a structured plan.



Your dog is lucky to have an owner willing to learn this much to take good care of them. May this new chapter bring more health, more energy, and many more years together.



**Thank you for trusting this
guide**

Natural Feeding for Dogs — The Complete Guide for
First-Time Owners